ladies, Hindu and Muslim, came to see the image in the morning and were similarly pleased with it. On another occasion, Akbar asked for the image because the elderly Hamida Banu had asked to see it too. Akbar carried it in his arms into her quarters himself, and called for his wives and children to see it again.

Finally, having understood perhaps that the Jesuits would not relinquish the image to him, Akbar asked to borrow the painting so his artists could study it. He called for all the best artists in the city, placed the image in a well-lit position, and commanded his painters to make copies of it. As many Hindu and Muslim courtiers were in attendance, the Jesuits seized the opportunity to talk to them all day about the mysteries of their faith. Though the courtiers usually regarded ‘with great contempt’ all that related to Christianity, this time, wrote the Jesuits, the Muslims were ‘willing listeners… and seemed to be pleased at what they heard’. Perhaps what the Muslim noblemen were best pleased at was that the Jesuits could now speak perfectly in Persian. Having struggled for many years with the language barrier, Father Xavier was now fluent in Persian, having spent years learning the language. Akbar had urged one of the Jesuits years ago to learn Persian, and advised them that a mastery of the language would ‘loose a great knot that now held him bound’. By 1601 Xavier was fluent enough ‘that the Persians themselves take pleasure in hearing him talk and all but admire the propriety of his vocabulary and the choiceness of his diction’. They were also much pleased with the particular accent he imparted to Persian words.

After the Padshah had kept the painting a few days, the Jesuits were obliged to part with their beloved painting twice more, to men of the highest standing in the land, one of whom was Mirza Aziz Koka. Aziz petitioned the Jesuits for the image so that his wives and daughters and daughters-in-law would have a chance to see the blessed Virgin and so these women, who had journeyed all the way to Mecca, were now able to gaze upon a holy Christian icon. This supremely urbane and cultured courtier then returned the painting, and sent his highest officer to the thoroughly unsettled Jesuits ‘to assure them that his services were at all times at their disposal’. He offered to pay the Jesuits whatever sum they asked for to buy the painting, even going so far as to express an interest in ‘the mystery of this Lady’. Aziz’s acute interest in European books and paintings despite his scathing religious indictment of their faith should have given the Jesuits a